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1930, Sufferings and Sacrifices

The impact of this tradition of martyrdom on Bhagat Singh was deep and everlasting. When, at the time of the 1921–1926 Gurdwara Reform Movement, the Sikh militant organization of the Babbar Khalsa Akali order saw six of their members executed on charges of having killed government officials and informers, Bhagat Singh, who could not have been more than eighteen years old at the time, wrote of them approvingly. He described them as men ‘showing great indifference to the trial’ and that when ‘after months, the judge gave his verdict’, what was to transpire was that there were ‘five to be hanged’ and many others were sent ‘for life imprisonment or exile’ in what is described as ‘their fond waiting for this day’. Such was their keenness in making the ultimate sacrifice that, upon hearing the verdicts, ‘the accused heroes thundered’ and ‘even the skies echoed with their triumphant slogans’. Bhagat Singh would have doubtless learnt from this. He would have early imbibed the lesson of how death should be embraced. For the right cause it was to be welcomed and even desired. The greater the injustice, the greater the need to make that personal sacrifice. Accordingly, when in the case of the Babbar Akalis it was decided that ‘an appeal was preferred’, paradoxically what happened now that ‘instead of five, now six were sent to the noose’. But it did not end there. More irony was to follow still when ‘the same day the news came that a mercy petition was sent’ then ‘the Punjab Secretary declared that the hanging would be put off’, but that astonishingly ‘on the very day of Holi’ on 27 February 1926, ‘when we were getting high on our enjoyment, a terrible thing was happening in a corner of this great province’. This was that ‘all of a sudden’ it came to be that ‘we saw a small contingent of mourners carrying the dead